

‘The king of Cochin accompanied by his Nayers’, reads the caption to this print from Abbé Prévost’s *Histoire générale des Voyages*, published in fifteen volumes between 1746 and 1759. Prévost’s ‘Nayres’ were the Nairs of Kerala, who regarded themselves a warrior people and acted accordingly. ‘They are all gentlemen,’ wrote Robert Johnson of the Nairs in his *Relations of the most famous kingdoms and commonweales of the world*, published in 1616. ‘At seven years of age they are put to school to learn the use of their weapons, where, to make them nimble and active, their sinews and joints are stretched by skilful fellows and are anointed